

12-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM · ALCOHOL-FREE

THE SOBER STRENGTH SYSTEM

A lifting program built around the first 90 days without alcohol — periodized to the recovery your body is actually doing, not the recovery a normal program assumes.

PHASE 01

The Anchor

Weeks 1–4

PHASE 02

The Build

Weeks 5–8

PHASE 03

The Claim

Weeks 9–12

FORMAT

Printable PDF

SESSIONS

3–4 / week

LEVEL

Beginner+

EQUIPMENT

Gym or home

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

STOPPING ALCOHOL CAN BE MEDICALLY DANGEROUS

If you drink heavily or daily, quitting suddenly without medical supervision can cause seizures, hallucinations, and delirium tremens, which can be fatal. **Do not use a training program as a substitute for medical detox.** Talk to a doctor, an addiction specialist, or call a helpline before you stop drinking. In the US, SAMHSA's National Helpline is **1-800-662-4357**, free and confidential, 24/7.

This program is written for someone who is **already past acute withdrawal** — either because they have been cleared by a clinician, are working with a treatment program, or were not physically dependent. It is a training plan, not a treatment plan.

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS NOT

- It is **not medical advice** and does not replace care from a doctor, therapist, or addiction professional.
- It is **not a recovery program**. It does not replace mutual-aid groups, counselling, or medication-assisted treatment. It is designed to sit alongside them.
- It is **not a diagnosis tool**. If drinking is harming your life, please speak to a professional.

PHYSICAL READINESS

Get medical clearance before starting any resistance training program, especially if you have liver disease, heart conditions, high blood pressure, a history of seizures, are pregnant, or are taking medication that affects heart rate, balance, or blood pressure. Stop immediately and seek help if you experience chest pain, dizziness, fainting, or unusual shortness of breath.

THE HONEST VERSION

Lifting will not keep you sober by itself. Nothing in a PDF will. What good training does is give the hardest hours of your day a shape, give your body a reason to recover, and put something on the calendar that you can win. That is a real and useful thing. It is not the whole thing.

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WHY YOUR TRAINING WAS NEVER THE PROBLEM

You have probably trained before while drinking. You may have trained hard. And the results never quite matched the work. That was not a discipline failure. There was a physiological ceiling on top of everything you did.

24–38%

Reduction in muscle protein synthesis measured when alcohol is consumed after training, even with optimal protein intake.

REM

Sleep architecture is suppressed by alcohol. Deep and REM sleep are when the bulk of recovery adaptation happens.

~30d

Typical point at which sleep quality is reported to substantially recover after stopping.

THE THREE LEVERS ALCOHOL WAS PULLING

- 1. Protein synthesis.** Resistance training creates the signal to build muscle. Alcohol blunts the response to that signal. Studies measuring myofibrillar protein synthesis after training found meaningful suppression even when protein was fed correctly. You were making the signal and then muting it.
- 2. Sleep.** Alcohol is sedating, which is not the same as restorative. It gets you unconscious and then fragments the back half of the night, cutting into exactly the sleep stages that support recovery and hormonal function.
- 3. Recovery debt.** Training damage plus alcohol processing plus poor sleep compounds. You showed up to the next session already behind, so you either trained fatigued or you skipped.

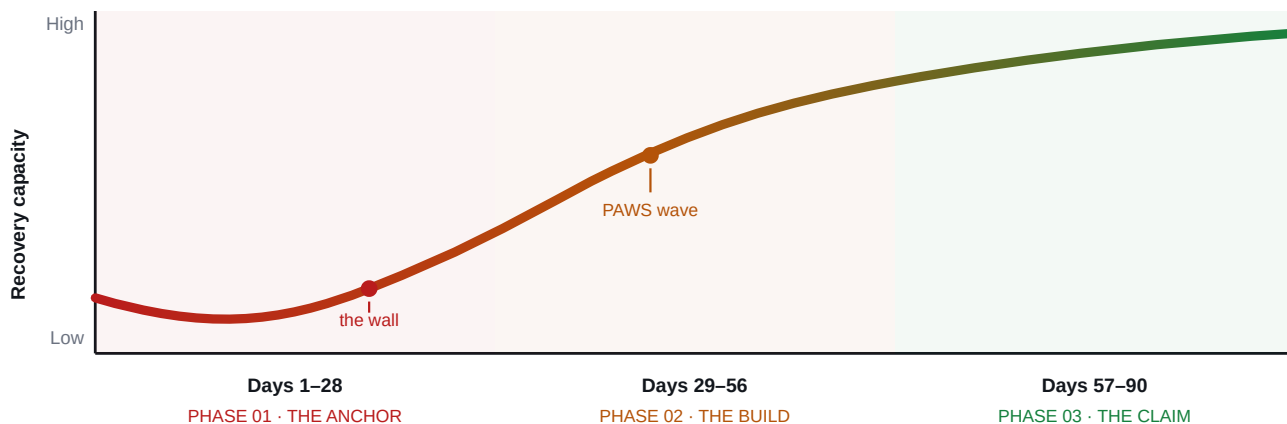
WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE NEXT 12 WEEKS

You are about to train with the ceiling removed. That is genuinely exciting and it is also the reason this program starts *easier* than you want it to. In weeks 1 to 4 your recovery capacity is not yet restored — the alcohol is gone, but the sleep debt, the fatigue, and the nervous system disruption are still being paid down. Train for the body you have in week 2, and you get to keep training in week 10.

Figures above summarise published research on alcohol and post-exercise muscle protein synthesis and on typical early-sobriety recovery timelines. Individual response varies substantially. Sources are listed on page 30.

THE 90-DAY RECOVERY CURVE

Your capacity to recover from training is not flat across these 90 days. It follows a rough, well-documented arc. Every phase of this program is matched to a segment of it.



WINDOW	WHAT IS HAPPENING IN YOUR BODY	WHAT TRAINING MUST DO
Days 1–28	Sleep is fragmented as REM rebounds. Fatigue is often at its worst. Cravings peak early. Appetite and blood sugar are unstable.	Build the habit. Low volume, never to failure. Frequency over intensity.
Days 29–56	Sleep quality substantially improves for most people. Energy returns, though post-acute withdrawal waves can still hit without warning.	Add volume. Introduce real progressive overload with an autoregulation rule.
Days 57–90	Recovery capacity is broadly restored. Protein synthesis is no longer being suppressed. This is when visible change tends to arrive.	Add intensity. Train heavier, prove the progress, test at week 12.

THE WALL AROUND WEEK 3

A very common pattern: the first week or two carries a burst of energy and optimism, then it drops out and you feel worse than when you started. This is expected and it is temporary. It is also precisely when most people abandon a training program. Phase 01 is deliberately easy enough to survive that week.

HOW THIS PROGRAM IS BUILT

Most programs assume your recovery is constant. This one assumes it is climbing, and loads you accordingly.

PHASE	DAYS	SESSIONS	HARD SETS	EFFORT	PRIMARY GOAL
01 • The Anchor	1–28	3 / wk	9–12	RPE 6–7	Attendance
02 • The Build	29–56	4 / wk	14–18	RPE 7–8	Volume and muscle
03 • The Claim	57–90	4 / wk	15–18	RPE 8–9	Strength and proof

READING THE EFFORT COLUMN

RPE means Rate of Perceived Exertion, scored by how many reps you had left in the tank. **RPE 6** = four reps left. **RPE 7** = three left. **RPE 8** = two left. **RPE 9** = one left. In Phase 01 you should finish every set feeling like you could have done several more. That is the instruction, not a lack of ambition.

THE FOUR RULES

RULE 1 — THE SESSION YOU COMPLETE BEATS THE SESSION YOU PLANNED

A shortened workout done on a bad day is worth more here than a perfect workout skipped. The streak is the asset.

RULE 2 — NEVER TRAIN TO FAILURE IN PHASE 01

Failure training costs recovery you do not currently have. It also makes the gym feel punishing, and you need it to feel like relief.

RULE 3 — LOG THE SOBER DAY NUMBER ON EVERY SESSION

Every log page has a Day column. Filling it in is the point. By week 12 the training log and the sobriety record are the same document, and that document is difficult to argue with.

RULE 4 — WHEN IN DOUBT, CHECK IN BEFORE YOU DECIDE

The Green / Amber / Red system on the next page decides what you do on hard days, so that a tired brain does not have to.

THE GREEN / AMBER / RED CHECK-IN

Sixty seconds, every morning, before you look at the day's session. Score two things honestly. The score picks the workout, so you never have to negotiate with yourself in the evening.

SCORE THIS	ASK YOURSELF
Last night's sleep	Slept fine · Broken or short · Barely slept at all
Craving right now	Quiet · Noticeable · Loud

GREEN

Slept fine and craving quiet.

Run the session exactly as written. Chase the prescribed load. This is a normal training day.

AMBER

Either sleep was broken or the craving is noticeable.

Run the session, but drop the final set of every exercise and cap all sets at RPE 7. Keep the first exercise as written. Expect about 70% of a normal session.

RED

Barely slept, or the craving is loud.

Do the Red Session below instead. Do not skip and do not push. The ritual is the objective today, not the stimulus.

THE RED SESSION · 20 MINUTES, ANYWHERE

BLOCK	WHAT YOU DO	TIME
Open	Walk. Outside if at all possible. No phone, no podcast, nothing in your ears for the first two minutes.	5 min
Work	Three easy rounds: 10 goblet squats or bodyweight squats · 10 push-ups from floor or wall · 20-second plank · 60-second walk.	10 min
Close	Walk again, slower. Then write the day number down somewhere you will see it tomorrow.	5 min

A RED DAY IS A COMPLETED DAY

Mark it in the log as done, not as missed. This matters more than it sounds. If Red days count as failures, you will start lying on the check-in to avoid them, and the whole system stops working.

TRAINING THE TRIGGER WINDOW

For most drinkers the danger is not spread evenly across the day. It clusters. Work ends, the house goes quiet, the evening opens up, and there is a shaped hole where a drink used to go. This program schedules training into that hole on purpose.

FIND YOUR WINDOW

Think back over the last month of drinking and answer plainly: what time did the first drink usually happen? For most people it lands somewhere between **5:00pm and 8:00pm**, on the transition from working to not working. Write yours here:

MY TRIGGER WINDOW

to

PLACE THE SESSIONS

- **First choice:** train inside the window. Start the session within thirty minutes of when the first drink used to happen. You are not just training, you are occupying the slot.
- **Second choice:** train immediately before it, so that the window opens with you already showered, fed, and physically tired.
- **Morning trainers:** if the gym has to be at 6am, that is fine — but you still need something in the evening window. Use Tier 1 or Tier 2 of the Substitution Ladder on the next page as a nightly anchor.

WHY THE GYM BAG GOES IN THE CAR THE NIGHT BEFORE

Every decision you have to make at 5:45pm is a decision that can go the other way. Pack the bag, book the class, set the alarm, tell someone you are going. Front-load every choice into a moment when you are not being asked to want it.

The evening does not need to be filled with something impressive. It needs to be filled with something scheduled.

THE SUBSTITUTION LADDER

For the moments when the craving arrives and training is not available — you are away, it is late, you have nothing with you. Work down the ladder until something fits. The rule is simple: **complete one tier before you make any decision about drinking.**

Tier 1
10 min

The Red Session, short form

Three rounds of 10 squats, 10 push-ups, 20-second plank. No equipment, no space required, no clothes to change into. Finish slightly out of breath.

Tier 2
5 min

Fifty and fifty

Fifty bodyweight squats and fifty push-ups, broken into as many sets as you need, in whatever you are wearing. Count out loud if you are alone. The counting occupies the part of your mind that is doing the negotiating.

Tier 3
2 min

Cold, breath, contact

Sixty seconds of cold water on your face, wrists, or a full cold shower. Then twenty slow breaths with a longer exhale than inhale. Then send one message to one person with your sober day number in it. You do not have to explain why.

Tier 4
30 sec

The door

Write your day number on the back of your hand. Put shoes on. Walk out of the front door and once around the block, or once around the building, or to the end of the corridor and back. Then reassess.

THE LADDER IS A BRIDGE, NOT A TREATMENT

These are tools for getting through a moment. They are not a substitute for a sponsor, a therapist, a meeting, or a crisis line. If the craving is overwhelming or you are in danger, contact your support network or call SAMHSA's National Helpline on **1-800-662-4357** (US, free, 24/7). Put the numbers you would actually call in your phone today, before you need them.

EQUIPMENT, SETUP, AND WARM-UP

WHAT YOU NEED

SETTING	WHAT THE PROGRAM ASSUMES
Full gym	Barbell, dumbbells, cable stack, leg press or hack squat, lat pulldown, benches. Everything runs as written.
Home, equipped	Adjustable dumbbells, a bench, and a pull-up bar or resistance bands. Use the substitution index on page 29.
Home, minimal	One pair of moderate dumbbells or a kettlebell, plus bands. Run every session, using substitutions, at higher reps.

THE WARM-UP · 6 MINUTES, EVERY SESSION

MOVEMENT	PRESCRIPTION	NOTE
Easy cardio	3 min	Bike, row, treadmill, or brisk walk. Enough to warm up, not enough to tire you.
Leg swings, front and side	10 each way	Hold something. Controlled, not ballistic.
Band pull-apart or arm circles	15	Wakes up the upper back before pressing.
Bodyweight squat	10	Slow, full depth if available to you.
Ramp-up sets	2 sets	On the first exercise only: one set at roughly half the working weight, one at about 75%.

REST BETWEEN SETS

Phase 01: 60 to 90 seconds. **Phase 02:** 90 seconds on isolation, 2 minutes on compounds. **Phase 03:** 2 to 3 minutes on the heavy first exercise, 90 seconds elsewhere. If you are watching the clock and it is making the session stressful, stop watching the clock and rest until your breathing is normal.

HOW TO ADD WEIGHT

When you hit the top of the prescribed rep range on every set of an exercise at the prescribed RPE, add weight next time. Smallest increment available: 5lb / 2.5kg on upper body, 10lb / 5kg on lower body. If you do not hit the top of the range, repeat the same weight. That is the whole progression model. It does not need to be more complicated than that.

THE ANCHOR

Days 1 to 28. The goal of this phase is not muscle. It is attendance. Twelve sessions completed in four weeks, at an effort level low enough that a bad night's sleep cannot take one away from you.

3×

Full-body sessions per week, roughly 45 minutes each

9–12

Hard sets per session — deliberately low

RPE 6–7

Always leave three or four reps in reserve

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Session A	Walk 20 min	Session B	Walk 20 min	Session C	Rest or walk	Rest

Shift the days to fit your life, but keep at least one day between sessions, and put each session inside or just before your trigger window.

THE WALKS ARE PART OF THE PROGRAM

Twenty minutes of easy walking on off days is not filler. It supports sleep, it burns off restless evening energy, and it gives the non-training days a shape too. Outside is better than a treadmill. Alone is fine.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE AT DAY 28

You have completed ten or more of the twelve sessions, including at least one Red Session that you counted as a win. You are lifting weights that feel comfortably manageable. You have not missed two sessions in a row. You may not look any different yet. That is not what this phase was for.

IF YOU RELAPSE DURING THIS PHASE

Go to the next scheduled session. Not the perfect one, not after a fresh start on Monday — the next one on the calendar. Reset the day counter in the log and keep the training streak running. The training does not have to start over just because the count did.

SESSION A · FULL BODY

Complete the 6-minute warm-up first. Rest 60 to 90 seconds between sets. Every set finishes with three or four reps still in the tank.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Goblet Squat	3	8–10	6–7	Elbows inside knees, chest tall, sit between the hips.
2	Dumbbell Bench Press	3	8–10	6–7	Shoulder blades pinned to the bench, wrists stacked.
3	One-Arm Dumbbell Row	3	10 / side	6–7	Pull to the hip, not the armpit. Pause one second.
4	Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift	3	10–12	6	Push hips back, soft knees, stop when hamstrings pull.
5	Plank	3	30 sec	—	Ribs down, glutes on. Stop when the hips sag.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 1	WK 2	WK 3	WK 4
Goblet Squat				
DB Bench Press				
One-Arm Row				
DB Romanian Deadlift				
Plank				
Sober day #				
Check-in G / A / R				

SESSION B · FULL BODY

Complete the 6-minute warm-up first. Rest 60 to 90 seconds between sets. Same instruction as Session A: leave reps in the tank.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift	3	8–10	6–7	Hinge, do not squat. Bar stays close to the legs.
2	Lat Pulldown or Assisted Pull-Up	3	8–10	6–7	Lead with the elbows, finish with the chest up.
3	Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press	3	10–12	6–7	Do not lean back. Stop just short of lockout.
4	Split Squat	3	8 / side	6	Back knee to the floor, front shin near vertical.
5	Dead Bug	3	8 / side	—	Lower back stays flat on the floor the whole time.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 1	WK 2	WK 3	WK 4
DB Romanian Deadlift				
Lat Pulldown / Pull-Up				
DB Shoulder Press				
Split Squat				
Dead Bug				
Sober day #				
Check-in G / A / R				

SESSION C · FULL BODY

The lightest of the three. Higher reps, easier loads. If a week has to lose a session, lose this one — but try not to.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Leg Press or Goblet Squat	3	12–15	6–7	Control the lowering. Do not let the lower back round.
2	Incline Dumbbell Press	3	10–12	6–7	Bench at 30 degrees, no higher.
3	Seated Cable Row	3	12–15	6–7	Chest stays up, no rocking for extra reps.
4	Dumbbell Curl	2	12	7	Elbows pinned to the ribs.
5	Triceps Pushdown	2	12–15	7	Upper arm does not move.
6	Farmer's Carry	3	30 sec	—	Tall posture, shoulders down, breathe.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 1	WK 2	WK 3	WK 4
Leg Press / Goblet Squat				
Incline DB Press				
Seated Cable Row				
DB Curl				
Triceps Pushdown				
Farmer's Carry				
Sober day #				

PHASE 01 ATTENDANCE BOARD

One mark per session. This page is the whole point of Phase 01 — twelve marks in four weeks. Print it and put it where you will see it.

WEEK	SESSION A	SESSION B	SESSION C	WALKS DONE	SOBER DAYS	BEST MOMENT
Week 1						
Week 2						
Week 3						
Week 4						

END OF PHASE REVIEW

QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Sessions completed out of 12	
How many were Red Sessions?	
Which day of the week was hardest?	
Is sleep better, worse, or the same as day 1?	
One thing to change for Phase 02	

MOVING ON

Go to Phase 02 if you completed at least eight of the twelve sessions. If you completed fewer, run Phase 01 again for another four weeks. There is no penalty for this and it is not a setback — the phase is doing its job either way, and Phase 02 will still be there.

THE BUILD

Days 29 to 56. Sleep is usually improving now, and with it your ability to actually recover from work. Volume goes up, a fourth session is added, and progressive overload becomes the organising idea.

4x

Upper / lower split, roughly 55 minutes per session

14–18

Hard sets per session, up from 9–12

RPE 7–8

Two or three reps left on working sets

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Upper A	Lower A	Walk	Upper B	Lower B	Walk or rest	Rest

THE PAWS PROTOCOL

Post-acute withdrawal does not arrive on schedule. You can have a good fortnight and then get flattened for three or four days by low mood, broken sleep, and cravings that feel like week one again. This is documented, common, and temporary. It is also the single most likely reason a Phase 02 lifter stops training.

WHEN A PAWS WAVE HITS

Do not deload the whole phase. Deload the week. For as long as the wave lasts, run every session at Amber rules: drop the last set of every exercise, cap everything at RPE 7, keep the first exercise as written. If two consecutive days score Red on the morning check-in, take the rest of that week at Red Sessions only, then pick the program back up exactly where you left it. Do not restart the phase and do not try to make up the missed volume.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE AT DAY 56

You have added weight to at least three of the main lifts since week 5. You survived at least one bad week without stopping. You are sleeping better than you were on day 1. Clothes may be starting to fit differently. Fourteen or more of the sixteen sessions are done.

UPPER A · STRENGTH EMPHASIS

Rest 2 minutes on exercises 1 and 2, 90 seconds on the rest. Ramp-up sets on exercise 1 only.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Barbell or DB Bench Press	4	6	7–8	Elbows about 45 degrees from the ribs. Touch and go, no bounce.
2	Pull-Up or Lat Pulldown	4	6–8	7–8	Full hang at the bottom, chin over or chest to bar.
3	Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press	3	8–10	7–8	Brace the abs so the ribs do not flare.
4	Chest-Supported Row	3	10–12	7–8	Squeeze for one second at the top of every rep.
5	Dumbbell Curl	3	10–12	8	Slow on the way down, three seconds.
6	Triceps Pushdown	3	12–15	8	Full lockout, control the return.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8
Bench Press				
Pull-Up / Pulldown				
DB Shoulder Press				
Chest-Supported Row				
DB Curl				
Triceps Pushdown				
Sober day # / Check-in				

LOWER A · STRENGTH EMPHASIS

Rest 2 minutes on exercises 1 and 2. If squats are new to you, use the goblet squat and add weight slowly.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Back Squat or Goblet Squat	4	6	7–8	Brace before you unrack. Depth you can control.
2	Romanian Deadlift	3	8	7–8	Hips back, spine neutral, stop at the stretch.
3	Leg Press	3	12	7–8	Do not let the lower back lift off the pad.
4	Seated or Lying Leg Curl	3	12	8	Two-second lower on every rep.
5	Standing Calf Raise	3	15	8	Full stretch at the bottom, pause at the top.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8
Squat				
Romanian Deadlift				
Leg Press				
Leg Curl				
Standing Calf Raise				
Sober day # / Check-in				

LEGS AND EVENING ENERGY

Lower body sessions are the most physically tiring in the program, which makes them the most useful ones to place inside the trigger window. If you can only put two sessions in that slot, make them Lower A and Lower B.

UPPER B · HYPERTROPHY EMPHASIS

Lighter loads, higher reps, shorter rests. Rest 90 seconds throughout. Chase the pump and the rep count, not the weight on the bar.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Incline Dumbbell Press	4	10	7–8	Stretch at the bottom, do not smash the dumbbells together.
2	Chest-Supported Row	4	10	7–8	Pull with the elbows, pause at the chest.
3	Lateral Raise	3	15	8	Light. Lead with the elbow, stop at shoulder height.
4	Lat Pulldown	3	12	8	Chest to the bar, no swinging.
5	Cable Fly or Pec Deck	3	15	8	Slight elbow bend, hold the squeeze.
6	Face Pull	3	15	8	Pull to the forehead, thumbs back.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8
Incline DB Press				
Chest-Supported Row				
Lateral Raise				
Lat Pulldown				
Cable Fly				
Face Pull				
Sober day # / Check-in				

LOWER B · HYPERTROPHY EMPHASIS

If deadlifts are new to you, use the trap bar or skip to Bulgarian split squats and add a set. Form before load, always.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Trap-Bar or Conventional Deadlift	3	5	7–8	Take the slack out of the bar before you pull. Reset every rep.
2	Bulgarian Split Squat	3	10 / side	7–8	Front foot far enough forward that the knee stays behind the toes.
3	Leg Extension	3	15	8	Pause one second at the top of every rep.
4	Hip Thrust or Glute Bridge	3	12	8	Chin tucked, ribs down, squeeze at the top.
5	Cable Crunch or Ab Wheel	3	12	8	Curl the spine, do not just hinge at the hips.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 5	WK 6	WK 7	WK 8
Deadlift				
Bulgarian Split Squat				
Leg Extension				
Hip Thrust				
Cable Crunch / Ab Wheel				
Sober day # / Check-in				

PHASE 02 ATTENDANCE BOARD

WEEK	UPPER A	LOWER A	UPPER B	LOWER B	SOBER DAYS	G / A / R COUNT
Week 5						
Week 6						
Week 7						
Week 8						

PROGRESS MARKERS · FILL IN AT DAY 56

MARKER	DAY 1	DAY 28	DAY 56
Bodyweight (optional)			
Bench or DB press top set			
Squat top set			
Pull-ups or pulldown top set			
Hours slept, typical night			
Energy at 6pm, 1 to 10			

ON THE SCALE

Bodyweight is listed as optional on purpose. Appetite is unstable in early sobriety, many people gain a little weight when they stop drinking, and a number on a scale is a poor and occasionally destabilising measure of what is happening here. If weighing yourself is unhelpful for you, skip that row entirely and use the strength rows. They are the better signal anyway.

THE CLAIM

Days 57 to 90. Recovery capacity is broadly restored, the suppression on protein synthesis is gone, and you have eight weeks of consistent training underneath you. This is the phase where the work starts paying visibly, and the phase that ends with proof.

4x

Upper / lower split, roughly 60 minutes per session

RPE 8–9

One or two reps left on the heavy top sets

Wk 12

Test week — record the numbers you started from

WEEKLY SCHEDULE

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Upper A	Lower A	Walk	Upper B	Lower B	Walk or rest	Rest

WHAT CHANGES IN THIS PHASE

- **Heavier top sets.** The first exercise of each session now runs in the 3 to 6 rep range at RPE 8, with longer rests of 2 to 3 minutes.
- **Back-off sets.** After the heavy top sets you drop roughly 15% and do a higher-rep set. This keeps the muscle-building volume while letting you train heavy.
- **The check-in still governs.** Green, Amber and Red do not stop applying because you feel good. Ninety days in, an Amber day is still an Amber day.

A NOTE ON THE NINETY-DAY MARK

Day 90 gets a lot of cultural weight, and some people find the days just after it strangely flat — the milestone arrives, nothing dramatic happens, and the structure that got you there suddenly has no obvious next target. Page 30 deals with this directly. Read it before you get to day 88, not after.

UPPER A · HEAVY PRESS

Rest 3 minutes after the top sets on exercise 1, 2 minutes on exercise 2, 90 seconds thereafter.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Bench Press — top sets	4	5	8	Ramp up over three warm-up sets. Spotter or safety pins.
2	Bench Press — back-off	1	10–12	8	Drop about 15% from the top set weight.
3	Weighted or Assisted Pull-Up	4	6	8	Add weight once you can do 8 clean bodyweight reps.
4	Overhead Press	3	8	8	Glutes and abs tight. Head through at the top.
5	Chest-Supported Row	3	10	8	Strict. No body English.
6	Curl + Pushdown superset	3	12 each	9	Back to back, 60 seconds rest after both.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 9	WK 10	WK 11	WK 12
Bench — top set				
Bench — back-off				
Pull-Up				
Overhead Press				
Chest-Supported Row				
Sober day # / Check-in				

LOWER A · HEAVY SQUAT

Rest 3 minutes after top sets. Use safety pins or a rack you trust. Never train a heavy squat to failure alone.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Back Squat — top sets	4	5	8	Big breath, brace, then descend. Same depth every rep.
2	Back Squat — back-off	1	10	8	Drop about 15%. This one will be unpleasant.
3	Romanian Deadlift	3	6–8	8	Heavier than Phase 02. Keep the bar on the legs.
4	Leg Press	3	10	8	Controlled, deep as your hips allow.
5	Leg Curl	3	12	9	Last set to two reps short of failure.
6	Standing Calf Raise	4	12–15	9	Pause at the top and the bottom.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 9	WK 10	WK 11	WK 12
Squat — top set				
Squat — back-off				
Romanian Deadlift				
Leg Press				
Leg Curl				
Sober day # / Check-in				

UPPER B · VOLUME

Rest 90 seconds throughout. This is the session that adds size. Take the last set of each isolation exercise close to failure.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Incline Dumbbell Press	4	8	8	Heavier than Phase 02. Full range.
2	Pull-Up or Lat Pulldown	4	8	8	Add weight or reps every week if you can.
3	Seated Dumbbell Press	3	10	8	Stop one rep short of grinding.
4	Lateral Raise	4	12–15	9	Last set: partial reps once full reps stop.
5	Cable Row	4	10	8	One-second squeeze every rep.
6	Face Pull	3	15	9	High elbows, external rotation at the end.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 9	WK 10	WK 11	WK 12
Incline DB Press				
Pull-Up / Pulldown				
Seated DB Press				
Lateral Raise				
Cable Row				
Sober day # / Check-in				

LOWER B · HEAVY PULL

The heaviest session in the program. Warm up thoroughly. If your lower back is not fresh, run this at Amber rules regardless of what the morning check-in said.

#	EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	RPE	COACHING CUE
1	Deadlift — top sets	3	3	8	Reset between every rep. Stop the set the moment the back rounds.
2	Front Squat or Hack Squat	3	8	8	Elbows high on front squats, or use the machine.
3	Bulgarian Split Squat	3	10 / side	8	Slow down, do not rush the reps.
4	Seated Leg Curl	4	12	9	Hamstrings take a beating from deadlifts — earn these.
5	Hip Thrust	3	10	8	Pause two seconds at lockout.
6	Ab Wheel or Cable Crunch	3	10–12	9	Do not let the lower back arch.

LOG · WEIGHT × REPS

EXERCISE	WK 9	WK 10	WK 11	WK 12
Deadlift — top set				
Front / Hack Squat				
Bulgarian Split Squat				
Seated Leg Curl				
Hip Thrust				
Sober day # / Check-in				

TEST WEEK

The last week of the program is not another training week. It is the receipt. Four sessions, each one built around finding a heavy set of three to five reps on one main lift, recorded next to the day number you reached.

HOW TO TEST A LIFT

1. Warm up thoroughly: five to eight reps at roughly 50%, three at 70%, one at 85%.
2. Take a set of five at what you believe is a hard but achievable weight.
3. If it moved well and you had two reps left, add 5 to 10% and take one more set of three.
4. Stop there. Two heavy sets is a test. Four is a competition and you are not in one.
5. Never test a squat, bench, or deadlift alone without safety pins or a spotter.

DAY	TEST LIFT	THEN FINISH WITH
Monday	Bench Press — heavy 5, then heavy 3	Pull-ups 3×8, curls and pushdowns 3×12
Tuesday	Back Squat — heavy 5, then heavy 3	Leg curl 3×12, calves 3×15
Thursday	Pull-Up or Pulldown — max clean reps	Incline press 3×10, lateral raise 3×15
Friday	Deadlift — heavy 3	Hip thrust 3×10, ab wheel 3×10

THE RECEIPT

LIFT	WEEK 1 WORKING WEIGHT	WEEK 12 TEST	CHANGE
Bench / DB Press			
Squat			
Deadlift			
Pull-Up / Pulldown			
Days alcohol-free			
Sessions completed of 44			

WRITE THE LAST ROW IN FIRST

Before you fill in a single lift number, fill in the days. The strength numbers are the interesting part. The day count is the part that made them possible.

EATING FOR A BODY IN EARLY RECOVERY

This is not a diet plan and it deliberately does not include one. Restriction in the first 90 days is a bad trade. Here are the few things that actually matter.

THE FOUR THAT MATTER

PRIORITY	THE TARGET	WHY IT MATTERS HERE
Eat enough	Maintenance calories at minimum through Phase 01 and 02.	Under-eating raises irritability, worsens sleep, and makes cravings louder. Do not diet and quit drinking in the same month.
Protein	Roughly 0.7 to 1g per pound of goal bodyweight, spread across three or four meals.	This is the input that the newly un-suppressed protein synthesis actually uses. It is the highest-leverage nutrition change you can make right now.
Carbohydrate	Do not cut them, especially around training.	Blood sugar is already unstable. Low-carb plus early sobriety is a recipe for the 4pm crash that sends people to the fridge or worse.
Fluid and salt	Drink to thirst plus a bit more. Do not fear salt unless a doctor told you to.	Hydration and electrolyte balance are often off in the first weeks and it shows up as headaches and fatigue.

ABOUT THE SUGAR CRAVINGS

Wanting sweets in the first weeks without alcohol is extremely common and it is not a character flaw. Alcohol is a large, fast source of calories and reward, and its removal leaves a gap the body tries to fill quickly. Let it, within reason, for the first four weeks. Fighting sugar and alcohol at the same time means fighting on two fronts with one supply line. Deal with sugar in month four if it still needs dealing with.

ONE THING WORTH ASKING A DOCTOR ABOUT

Heavy drinking is associated with deficiencies in several nutrients, including thiamine (vitamin B1), folate, and magnesium. Some of these matter a great deal and thiamine deficiency in particular can be serious. Do not self-prescribe from a supplement aisle — ask a doctor whether bloodwork or supplementation makes sense for you. This is a question for a clinician, not for a training PDF.

EXERCISE SUBSTITUTION INDEX

Every exercise in the program, with a machine option, a dumbbell option, and a no-equipment option. Swap freely — the pattern matters far more than the implement.

PRESCRIBED	MACHINE / CABLE	DUMBBELL / BAND	BODYWEIGHT ONLY
Back Squat	Hack squat, leg press	Goblet squat	Bodyweight squat, high reps
Goblet Squat	Leg press	Dumbbell squat	Bodyweight squat
Deadlift	Back extension	Dumbbell RDL	Single-leg hip hinge
Romanian Deadlift	Seated leg curl	Dumbbell RDL	Nordic curl negative
Split Squat / Bulgarian	Smith machine lunge	Dumbbell split squat	Bodyweight split squat
Leg Press	Hack squat	Goblet squat, high reps	Wall sit, 45 sec
Leg Curl	Cable leg curl	Band leg curl	Nordic curl, glute bridge walkout
Leg Extension	—	Band leg extension	Sissy squat, assisted
Hip Thrust	Hip thrust machine	Dumbbell hip thrust	Glute bridge, single leg
Bench Press	Chest press machine	Dumbbell bench press	Push-up, feet elevated
Incline Press	Incline machine press	Incline dumbbell press	Decline push-up
Overhead Press	Shoulder press machine	Dumbbell shoulder press	Pike push-up
Pull-Up	Lat pulldown, assisted pull-up	Band-assisted pull-up	Inverted row under a table
Chest-Supported Row	Seated cable row	Chest-supported DB row	Inverted row
One-Arm Row	Seated cable row	Dumbbell row	Backpack row
Lateral Raise	Cable lateral raise	Dumbbell lateral raise	Band lateral raise
Face Pull	Cable face pull	Band pull-apart	Prone Y raise
Cable Fly	Pec deck	Dumbbell fly	Wide push-up
Curl	Cable curl	Dumbbell curl	Band curl, towel curl
Triceps Pushdown	Cable pushdown	Overhead DB extension	Close-grip push-up, dip
Calf Raise	Calf raise machine	Dumbbell calf raise	Single-leg calf raise on a step
Cable Crunch	Ab machine	Ab wheel	Dead bug, hollow hold

DAY 91 AND THE ROAD AFTER

The program ends. The thing it was built to support does not. Here is what to do with the week after test week, so that finishing does not feel like stopping.

PICK YOUR NEXT TWELVE WEEKS BEFORE DAY 90 ARRIVES

- **Run it again, heavier.** Start Phase 02 from your test week numbers and repeat Phases 02 and 03. This is the simplest option and it works for a long time.
- **Go to a dedicated strength or hypertrophy program.** You now have twelve weeks of training history and honest numbers. Most intermediate programs will accept you.
- **Add something with other people in it.** A class, a club, a lifting partner, a running group. The training has been solo by design so it could not be derailed by scheduling. That was for the first 90 days, not forever.

KEEP THE CHECK-IN

Whatever program comes next, keep the Green / Amber / Red morning check-in and keep logging the day number. They cost nothing, they outlast this document, and they are the two habits most worth carrying forward.

You did not just get stronger over these twelve weeks. You built a piece of evidence that the evenings can be filled with something else. Keep the evidence somewhere you can find it.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Parr EB et al. *Alcohol Ingestion Impairs Maximal Post-Exercise Rates of Myofibrillar Protein Synthesis following a Single Bout of Concurrent Training*. PLOS ONE, 2014. · Barnes MJ. *The Effects of Alcohol Consumption on Recovery Following Resistance Exercise: A Systematic Review*. Journal of Functional Morphology and Kinesiology, 2019. · SAMHSA National Helpline, 1-800-662-4357. · Early-sobriety symptom timelines summarised from published clinical and treatment-provider guidance; individual experience varies substantially.

Disclaimer. This document is for general educational and informational purposes only. It is not medical advice, not a substitute for professional medical or psychological care, and not a treatment for alcohol use disorder. Consult a qualified healthcare professional before beginning any exercise program or making changes to alcohol consumption. Alcohol withdrawal can be life-threatening and may require medical supervision. The author and publisher accept no liability for any injury, loss, or damage arising from the use of this material. If you are in crisis, contact emergency services or a crisis helpline immediately.